

THURSDAY, JULY 16, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 20 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

NPCIL: Kudankulam data breach not linked to nuclear security

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 15

FOLLOWING REPORTS of a data breach at the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant, the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) said on Wednesday that the leaked information does not pertain to any nuclear safety or security systems.

In a statement, NPCIL said the compromised data relates only to the plant's conventional Balance of Plant (BoP) common service facilities, for which Reliance Infrastructure Ltd was

awarded a contract in 2018.

Located in Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu, Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant consists of six units of Pressurised Water Reactors of VVER design, which were established in technical collaboration with Russia. The first two units (KKNPP Units-1 & 2) are already in operation, while Units 3 and 4 are still under construction and are due to be operational by 2027. The remaining two units are at different stages of progress.

The present data breach is related to Units 3 and 4.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

SAYS MAY SUPPORT IF 50% INCREASE IN SEATS IN ALL STATES

Delimitation Bill: Ahead of House session, Sule signals options open

Says INDIA bloc to take collective call, plays down crossover buzz

Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, July 15

SIGNALLING ANOTHER break in the Opposition ranks ahead of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, the Sharad Pawar-led NCP(SP)'s working president and MP Supriya Sule on Wednesday said her party

**NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule in Mumbai, Wednesday.** AKASH PATIL

would consider supporting the Centre's proposed delimitation Bill if it ensures a 50 per cent increase in the Lok Sabha seats in all states.

Sule's remarks came amid reports that sections of the

NCP(SP)'s MPs and MLAs were increasingly pushing for a tie-up with the ruling BJP-led NDA.

There has been a buzz about the NCP(SP)'s next moves in the wake of a series of meetings between its leaders and senior BJP and government functionaries over the last several days.

With the Parliament session getting underway on July 20, the Narendra Modi government has stepped up its efforts to muster a two-thirds majority to push a fresh constitutional amendment Bill to advance reservation for women to 2029 – along with a delimitation Bill

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NEW GOLD STANDARD: UK ENVOY

India-UK trade deal kicks in: PM says boost for farmers & MSMEs

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 15

THE INDIA-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), under which 99 per cent of Indian goods entering the UK and 90 per cent of UK goods entering India will either be duty-free or attract reduced tariffs, came into force on Wednesday.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi described the operationalisation of the agreements as "a significant moment in the India-UK partnership". British High Commissioner Lindy Cameron called it the "new

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

**British High Commissioner to India Lindy Cameron addresses the media in New Delhi on Wednesday.** ANI

EXPLAINED

WHAT CHANGES FOR CONSUMERS AND INDUSTRY [PAGE 12](#)

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 16~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.



Strategic Dialogue

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Belgium's Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs Maxime Prévot during the India-Belgium Strategic Dialogue in Brussels on Wednesday. PTI

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Sule

for expansion of the Lok Sabha from 543 MPs up to 850 – which was defeated in the Lower House in the April special session. Along with other INDIA bloc allies, the NCP (SP) had then voted against this constitutional amendment Bill.

On Wednesday, Sule told The Indian Express that “If the Union government amends the delimitation Bill by bringing a 50% increase in seats, then we will support it. This is not something new that I am saying. We have always maintained that we will support the Bill if these amendments are brought. There is no change in our stand.”

However, later in the day, addressing a press conference, Sule appeared to water down her stance. “We haven’t received any Bill on delimitation as of now. Previously, when the Bill was brought, the Opposition raised the amendment of increasing seats by 50 per cent. Whenever the Bill is presented to us, we will discuss it with the INDIA bloc parties. We will make a collective decision. It is important that the delimitation formula is also presented to us and we are told how new demarcation will be done,” she said.

Hours later, Sule calibrated her position further. “Recent re-

ports appearing in sections of the media regarding the stand of the NCP(SP) on the issue of delimitation are inaccurate and speculative. I wish to clarify that neither I nor the party has had any official discussion with any media organisation on this subject,” she said in a post on X.

“As with every issue of constitutional importance, our party’s position is determined only after detailed consultations within the party and with our allies – India alliance... Since no such Bill has yet been made available, any speculation regarding its contents or our position would be premature,” said Sule, Pawar’s daughter.

Sule also told the press conference that the demand to increase seats by 50 per cent had been raised by several Opposition parties, including the Trinamool Congress (TMC), Samajwadi Party (SP) and DMK, when the legislation was first introduced in Parliament. “All of us, including the TMC, SP and the DMK, had taken this position. It is not something that is being said for the first time,” she said.

When asked about speculations about the NCP(SP)’s legislators looking to “cross over to the NDA” or “merge with the NCP”, Sule said there was no such proposal before the party. “Nobody has asked about this,

pressed the desire to switch over. All stand united with Sharad Pawar and will follow every decision to be taken by Sharad Pawar,” she said.

Sule played down reports about the NCP(SP)’s alleged proximity to the BJP, and also its state party president Jayant Patil’s meeting with Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis late on Tuesday night.

“When I was in Lucknow for a Parliamentary committee meeting, I openly met Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. If our party really wanted to ally with the BJP, we would not be meeting openly,” she said.

Patil had met Fadnavis hours after calling on Sharad Pawar at his Mumbai residence. Senior leaders of the BJP’s ally NCP, Sunil Tatkare and Praful Patel, also met CM Fadnavis separately the same night, fueling fresh buzz over political realignments.

Sources told The Indian Express that these meetings came against the backdrop of a “rethink” within the NCP (SP), with at least half of its 10 MLAs favouring a switch to the NDA while arguing that remaining in the Opposition has made it increasingly difficult to secure development funds and administrative clearances for their constituencies.

Patil, however, also sought to

downplay his meeting with Fadnavis. “I met the Chief Minister to discuss the issue of disqualifying the chairman of the Islampur Municipal Council. I do not know about the meeting between Tatkare, Patel and the CM,” he said. He dismissed reports of merger talks with the NCP. “I have not met Tatkare and Patel regarding any merger plans. After the death of Ajit Pawar, no such discussion has taken place,” he said, adding he felt “sad” whenever the media discussed him leaving the party.

The political chatter over the NCP(SP)’s possible bid to switch to the NDA fold intensified after six Shiv Sena (UBT) Lok Sabha MPs recently joined the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, citing better access to government approvals and development funds. That, sources said, has prompted sections within the NCP (SP) to argue that the party should also reconsider its position.

Although the NCP (SP), with 10 MLAs and eight Lok Sabha MPs, is the smallest among Maharashtra’s six major political parties, its parliamentary strength has assumed significance as the NDA looks to secure the support of a two-thirds majority in both Houses to ensure the passage of several key legislation, including a fresh women’s quota Bill along with a delimitation legislation.

Trade

gold standard of trade deals”. Alongside CETA, the Agreement on Social Security (Double Contribution Convention) exempts Indian professionals on temporary UK assignments of up to 60 months from making social security contributions in both countries, reducing costs for employees and employers.

“With the coming into force of the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement and the Agreement on Social Security, our economic linkages are going to get even deeper. Together, these agreements translate our shared ambition into tangible opportunities for our people,” Modi said in a post on X.

He said the trade pact would provide fresh momentum to farmers, entrepreneurs and micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), while giving several sectors “stronger access” to the UK market. He said it would deepen cooperation in technology, professional services and innovation, while supporting greater mobility for skilled Indian talent.

“The social security agreement will provide invaluable support to Indian professionals working temporarily in the UK and strengthen the competitiveness of Indian enterprises,” Modi said. The Prime Minister added that the agreements reflected “the trust between our democracies and our resolve to build a forward-looking partnership driven by trade, technology, investment and innovation”.

Cameron termed it as “the new gold standard of trade deals: pro-worker, pro-innovation, and pro-growth”. “It’s a force multiplier and a template for a future trade agreement,” she said.

Citing UK Minister for Trade, Chris Bryant, she said the UK-India FTA (free trade agreement) “sends a message to the rest of the world that the rules-based

order works, and I think those rules, when they are about international trade, are in every-

body’s interest and certainly very much in UK-India’s interest”. “The UK-India trade deal brings sweeping benefits for a wide range of sectors. From today, import duty on Scotch whisky has been cut from 150 per cent to 75 per cent, which should make a really significant difference to the price the consumer pays,” she said.

Cameron also said that import duties on premium UK-built cars will begin to fall from over 110 per cent to 10 per cent, making British cars cheaper for Indian consumers.

To celebrate the occasion, a special package of select British goods arrived at the British Deputy High Commission in Mumbai on Wednesday morning aboard a British Airways flight. “The package contained goods from the UK benefitting from reduced tariffs, including cosmetics, food products and alcoholic beverages,” said a statement.

The trade agreement, signed in July last year, is expected to benefit a wide range of sectors on both sides, including automotive, manufacturing, consumer goods, creative industries and medical technology. It lowers tariffs across sectors, including textiles, leather, gems and jewellery, engineering goods, marine products and pharmaceuticals while expanding market access for services, digital trade and government procurement.

According to government data, merchandise trade between the two countries stood at US\$ 25.1 billion in 2025-26, while bilateral services trade was US\$ 35.4 billion in 2024. The agreement is expected to at least double bilateral trade from about 48 billion pounds annually by 2030. “The agreement, which opens new avenues for trade, investment and innovation, will create unique opportunities for our businesses,” Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on X.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said goods worth US\$ 140 million were shipped on the agreement’s first day. WITH PTI

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

Kudankulam data

NPCIL said the Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) contract for BoP common services package was awarded to Reliance Infrastructure Ltd in 2018 through a public tender process. The scope of the contract included engineering, procurement/supply, construction and commissioning of common service facilities.

“These facilities are of conventional nature and are typically found in thermal power plants as well as other process industries. They are not related to nuclear safety or nuclear security systems,” NPCIL said.

NPCIL said it provided indicative drawings and technical specifications to the bidders as part of the public tendering process. “Based on these inputs and the requirements of the project, the EPC contractor, M/s Reliance Infrastructure Ltd, prepared detailed engineering drawings in consultation with the respective Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs). The designs proposed by Reliance Infra Ltd, meeting the technical specifications, are accepted by NPCIL after review,” it said.

On Wednesday, Reuters reported that ransomware group World Leaks had published a large cache of files purportedly linked to the Kudankulam Nu-

clear Power Plant on the dark web. The leaked archive, reportedly online since June 11, contains nearly 19,000 files totalling about 14.3 gigabytes, it said.

The report said that the documents span the period from 2016 to mid-2025, and include blueprints, supplier information, meeting and inspection records, equipment reviews and insurance policies.

The Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group, whose subsidiary Reliance Infrastructure Ltd was awarded the EPC contract in 2018, told Reuters in a statement that there had been a “partial breach” of its data on a server hosted by third-party Indian data centre service provider Yotta, and the government had been informed about the incident.

The report also quoted Yotta’s statement that it had noted suspicious activity on May 29 on a server it hosts that belongs to Reliance Infrastructure. It said the activity was immediately terminated and the suspected ransomware execution was prevented, but Reliance Infrastructure informed it at the end of June that there had been claims of a data breach made by “external threat actors”, according to the report.

Names deleted from Bengal rolls entitled to certain benefits, says SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 15

OBSERVING THAT those deleted from the electoral rolls in West Bengal may still be entitled to some benefits like ration, the Supreme Court on Wednesday asked a man who sought non-cancellation of ration card to move the jurisdictional High Court.

“You are right. Even if your name is removed from the electoral roll, you are entitled to certain benefits. But those benefits can be granted by the High Court very well...”, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant presiding over a three-judge bench remarked orally. The bench also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a plea by West Bengal resident Mohibulla Mondal, seeking its intervention to prevent cancellation or suspension of his ration card.

He referred to a June 4 order issued by the state’s Department

of Food and Supplies last month and expressed apprehension that he may be denied ration as his name was deleted during the revision.

The petitioner added that his appeal challenging his deletion from voters list is pending before the appellate tribunal set by the SC.

Senior Advocate Shadan Farasat said the question would arise in several matters and the SC should clarify the position in any one matter.

The CJI said “...we will clarify in 100 matters if need be. But we are quite sure the High Courts will not give us a chance to clarify. They will understand this very well. You are entitled to certain benefits. Go through jurisdictional High Courts, they will grant it.” The CJI added that if Mondal’s appeal is allowed by the Tribunal, then the entire exercise would become academic. The SC meanwhile also asked the Tribunal to decide the appeal preferably in two months.

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 15

The house-to-house visits by Booth Level Officers (BLOs), which began on June 30 and was originally scheduled to conclude by July 29, will now continue till August 8. The final electoral roll will now be published on October 19 instead of October 10.

Delhi has more than 1.45 crore voters. While enumeration forms have been distributed to over 99% of these electors, forms of only around 21.75 lakh or 14.99% electors have been digitised so far, shows data provided by the Chief Electoral Office (CEO) of Delhi.

District Name	Enumeration forms distributed	Enumeration forms digitised
Old Delhi	100%	9.09%
East	99.66%	9.21%
South East	99.24%	9.47%
Central	99.75%	11.19%
North East	100%	11.71%



“We have extended the deadlines so that the least number of people are excluded from the draft rolls,” an official from the CEO office said.

“If BLOs are given more time to complete their work, the digitisation and verification processes will see less instances of mismatch in details...,” the official explained.

Old Delhi, East Delhi and Southeast Delhi have emerged as the worst performing districts in terms of digitisation of forms, with the figure standing at less than 10%. The Central, Northeast and South districts have digitised 11.19%, 11.71% and 11.79% forms respectively.

The only two districts to have digitised over one-fifth re-

muneration forms are South-west at 21.80% and Outer North at 29.57%.

“Several people are taking time to understand the process. Correcting forms of those who make mistakes also takes a lot of time,” said Neha Rawat, a school teacher deployed as a BLO in West Delhi’s Moti Nagar. “I am awake late into the night doing SIR work after putting my children to sleep.”

Naresh, a primary school teacher on BLO duty in Najafgarh's Dharampura Extension said BLOs also have to fill forms on behalf of many. "Every form takes around 10-12 minutes."

The draft electoral rolls will be out on August 17 instead of August 5. The window for filing claims and objections, which earlier was August 5-September 4, is August 17-September 16 now. Claims and objections can now be disposed of by October 15 against the previous deadline of October 3.

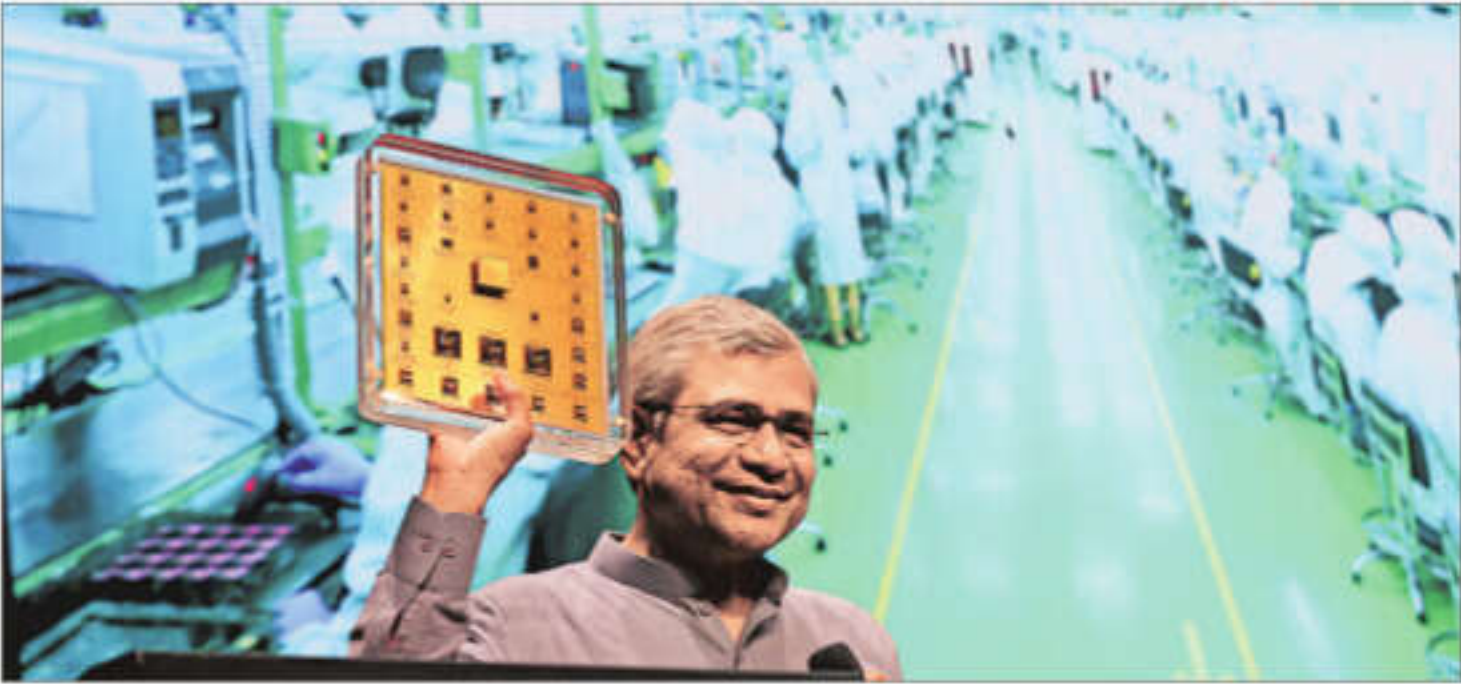
Eye on supply chain, Cabinet approves Rs 1.27 lakh crore semiconductor push

Rs 62,500-crore mobile making scheme cleared
Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 15

THE UNION Cabinet on Wednesday approved the second iteration of India's ambitious Semiconductor Mission, with an outlay of Rs 1.27 lakh crore. The fresh six-year initiative will focus on subsidising the supply chain related to chip manufacturing in order to attract companies producing commodities like gases and chemicals used in production.

The Cabinet also approved a Rs 62,500-crore mobile phone manufacturing push — a five-year follow-on to the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for smartphone assembly, which helped India successfully localise production. Compared to the first iteration of the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM), Government incentives have been slashed in the 2.0 version. For instance, the first scheme carried a uniform capex subsidy of 50% for fabrication and assembly plants. Under ISM 2.0, however, silicon plants will receive a subsidy of 40%, and other units 35%. Similarly, the incentive for advanced packaging has been kept at 35%, and 25% for the conventional version.

ISM 2.0 will also offer Government subsidies for research and development, and for talent development in the semiconductor sector. India's foray into semiconductor produc-



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw showcases 'Made in India' semiconductor chips during the Cabinet briefing in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANIL SHARMA
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

tion and packaging has been outlined as a strategic move to insert itself into the global chip supply chain and deepen domestic value addition in its electronics sector. Used to power devices from toasters to fighter jets, semiconductors have become a critical resource amid heightened geopolitical tensions over the last few years.

By 2029, India expects to achieve the capability to design and manufacture chips required for nearly 70-75% of domestic applications, and by 2035, the country aims to be among the top semiconductor nations globally. ISM 1.0, launched in 2021, was conceived as a state-backed push to build a full-stack chip ecosystem, from fabrication and packaging to design and display manufacturing. Under the scheme, cumulative investments of around Rs 1.64 lakh crore have been committed. In this year's Union Budget, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced ISM 2.0 to produce equipment and materials, design full-stack Indian IP and fortify supply chains.

Under ISM 1.0, the Government has approved a total of 12 chip plants, including various assembly and testing (ATMP/OSAT) plants being set up by the likes of Micron Technology, and a chip fabrication facility being developed by Tata Electronics in partnership with Taiwan's PSMC. These plants are being constructed in states including Gujarat, Assam, Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Odisha. At least three of these, including Micron, Kaynes Semicon and CG Semi, have started commercial production, though the fab is still under construction. These chips are also being exported.

The *Indian Express* first reported that the IT Ministry had prepared a blueprint for ISM 2.0 with an outlay of \$15 billion —

their contract manufacturing partners, establishing smartphones as one of the country's biggest export categories. Following the scheme, India has managed to take local value addition in the sector to 24%, compared to China's rate of 38%.

Under the fresh scheme, the Government has focused on local sourcing to boost domestic value addition, and on design and R&D by Indian brands, along with incentives linked to the export of smartphones, Union IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said. In line with sales-linked incentives under the PLI for smartphones, the fresh scheme provides incentive support on eligible sales for manufacturing of mobile phones in India at differentiated rates ranging from 2.25% to 5%.

The scheme will also provide an additional incentive of up to 1.5% linked to domestic sourcing of key components/sub-assemblies. For building Indian brands, an additional incentive at the rate of 3% on eligible sales will apply for design and R&D of the product. The scheme targets cumulative production of Rs 39 lakh crore during its tenure, up from Rs 22 lakh crore achieved under the previous PLI scheme. It aims to generate 60,000 direct jobs in mobile manufacturing and other sectors. Under the PLI scheme for smartphones, nearly 2 lakh jobs were created.

Vaishnaw said that under the PLI scheme, over Rs 19,000 crore was disbursed as incentives, while the Government collected direct taxes worth Rs 25,000 crore and Rs 3 lakh crore in GST from the smartphone industry.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

National Investment Policy to boost urea production

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 15

THE CENTRE on Wednesday approved the National Investment Policy (NIP) for Urea-2026, which aims to make the country self-reliant in the production of fertiliser, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told the media on Wednesday.

A proposal of this effect was approved by the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The CCEA approved the proposal piloted by the Department of Fertilizers. According to a statement, the policy will encourage new investments in the urea sector for setting up gas-based manufacturing units in India.

"Setting up of new urea manufacturing units will be covered under the NIP for Urea-2026 for Atmanirbhar Bharat (NIPU-2026)," the statement said, adding that under the New Investment Policy-2012, six new urea units have been set up, including four through Joint Venture Companies of nominated PSUs, and two by private companies. The period for new investment under NIP-2012 expired in October 2019. "There are 33 operational urea-manufacturing units with reassessed/installed capacity of 269.42 LMT. There is a need to increase the indigenous production of urea."

Auditor General finds Chhattisgarh's mining welfare fund strayed from its core purpose

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, July 15

A COMPTROLLER and Auditor General (CAG) audit has exposed systemic lapses in the implementation of the Pradhan Mantri Khanij Kshetra Kalyan Yojana (PMKKKY) in Chhattisgarh, flagging governance failures, policy deviations, fund diversion, tender violations, unfruitful expenditure and transparency gaps in the utilisation of the state's Rs 13,101-crore District Mineral Foundation Trust (DMFT) fund between 2015-16 to 2023-24.

Launched in 2015, PMKKKY aims to implement development programmes for the welfare of mining-affected areas and people through District Mineral Foundation Trusts (DMFTs), which receive contributions from mining and quarry leaseholders.

DMFTs received Rs 13,101 crore up to 2023-24, of which Rs 10,253 crore (78%) was spent on various works in Chhattisgarh.

The audit found deviations in the CGDMFT Rules, 2015, diluting benefits meant for mining-affected communities. The definition of "Affected People" was expanded to include all people living or working in af-

ected areas, extending coverage across mining-affected districts without specific limitations.

As a result, trusts allocated Rs 709.47 crore to distribute free items among people in directly and indirectly affected areas. Audit scrutiny of 30 cases worth Rs 28.11 crore found distributions were made without defined criteria or identified beneficiaries, resulting in funds being spent on broader community schemes instead of the intended mining-affected population.

Despite spending Rs 4,536.58 crore (81% of available funds), 754 (44%) of the 1,734 directly affected villages remained uncovered in 11 sampled districts.

Trust funds were also spent on non-eligible works such as welcome gates, gardens in collectorates, renovation and construction of government office buildings, office purchases, official vehicles and grants to private educational institutions.

Funds were utilised without preparing master plans, vision documents or annual plans to ensure sustainable livelihoods in mining areas. Affected areas were identified with delays ranging five months to five years after trusts were constituted, while Rs 1,060.70 crore was allocated before areas were identified.

SC considers SOP to hear urgent life and liberty cases after working hours

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 15

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday agreed to consider implementing a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) to facilitate access to constitutional courts during off-duty hours in urgent matters involving questions of life and personal liberty.

A three-judge bench, presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, issued notice on a plea filed by Advocate Maheravish Rein, who said that, as of now, litigants find it difficult to access the courts at night.

“My grievance is if I am a poor man, I want to have access to justice, I can only access the legal aid committee during the day, not at night. I can access the court only during the day, not at night,” she told the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

She referred to Article 32(4) of the Constitution which says, “The right guaranteed by this Article (to move the SC for enforcement of fundamental rights) shall not be suspended except as otherwise provided for by this Constitution.”

She submitted that even in urgent matters, when applications are filed, the litigants have to wait until the next morning for them to be heard.

The CJI said that, though it does not happen regularly, many a time lawyers file vague applications. “I don’t say it’s a regular practice, but sometimes vague applications are filed. How can such matters be listed

on the same day?,” the CJI said.

Justice Bagchi pointed out that there have been instances when the SC has sat even at night, but counsel said this does not happen in every needy litigant’s case.

Justice Bagchi said, “What you want is official hours and unofficial hours to become the same; we do not agree to that.”

The judge added, “There is difference between access to justice during official hours. There is a difference and a different criterion proposed to access to justice beyond official hours. If that was not there, your case is made out of non-access. But a graded access to justice is not denial of justice.”

Issuing notice to High Courts on the plea, the CJI asked the counsel to “give some concrete solutions, some SOP as to what is the procedure that can be followed after court hours which according to you will ensure access to justice”.

CJI Kant recalled that he had “earlier made a request to High Courts that you start working 24x7 like government hospitals. If I can make a request to High Courts, then why not SC (Supreme Court)? But tell us what the SOP is. Because mere announcement is not going to serve any purpose unless it is implemented at the ground level”.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who was present in court, said it would be better if the SC examined it on administrative grounds rather than asking the High Courts to do so at this stage.

Stone-pelting, arson, teargas as mob targets Assam Rifles camp in Manipur

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 15

TENSIONS ESCALATED in Manipur’s Senapati district on Tuesday night, after a mob gathered at an Assam Rifles camp in Senapati town following the security force’s launch of a search operation for suspected armed cadres of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (Isak-Mui-vah) (NSCN (IM)), said a defence spokesperson.

The mob resorted to stone-pelting, arson and vandalism at the camp, and security forces resorted to firing blank rounds and teargas grenades to disperse them, said officials.

According to a Ministry of Defence spokesperson, the Assam Rifles had launched an area domination patrol and search operation on Tuesday based on “credible intelligence inputs regarding the presence of armed cadres in the general area of Makuilongdi, approximately 2 kilometres west of the designated NSCN (IM) camp at Ok-long” in Senapati.

The NSCN (IM) has been in a ceasefire agreement with the Centre since 1997, and according



Charred remains of a vehicle after a mob attacked an Assam Rifles camp late Tuesday in Senapati district, Manipur. PTI

to the spokesperson, their intelligence inputs and posts on social media indicated the presence of armed cadres outside designated camps, in violation of the Ceasefire Ground Rules.

The official Ceasefire Monitoring Group was also formally informed about this.

“During the course of the operation, the Assam Rifles col-

umns approaching Makuilongdi and Oklong villages were obstructed by residents, involving women. The columns exercised maximum restraint and communicated with the local representatives, assuring that the operations were aimed solely at ensuring security and maintaining peace in the area and that the col-

umns would not enter any village without the consent of the authorities,” said an official.

Tensions continued to escalate, culminating in a large crowd gathering at Senapati town at around 9 pm and beginning to march towards the Assam Rifles camp, where they reportedly pelted stones and attempted arson. The Senapati police and CRPF were deployed to disperse the mob, and blank rounds and teargas grenades were fired.

“Later, while retreating, a section of the mob vandalised and damaged Assam Rifles vehicles. One light vehicle was set ablaze, while two trucks were overturned and damaged. A civil car was also reportedly burnt during the violence. Through the coordinated efforts of the security forces, Manipur Police and CRPF personnel, the situation was brought under control and the crowd fully dispersed by midnight. The situation in Senapati is presently peaceful and under control. No injuries or casualties were sustained by the local population or security force personnel,” said the official.

IIT Bombay’s new finding could make drug discovery ‘faster, cheaper, more sustainable’

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, July 15

SCIENTISTS AT IIT Bombay have found a novel and efficient way to convert simple, abundantly-available, straight-chain carbon compounds into complex ring-shaped molecules that can be building blocks for medicinal or other valuable chemicals.

Their new method claims to solve a long-standing problem in synthetic chemistry: Conversion of long, straight-chain carbon molecules into ring-shaped molecules, which, at present, involves a multi-step process that is time-consuming and expensive. The research, led by Professor Debabrata Maiti of IIT Bombay, has been published in the prestigious Nature journal. Maiti said the newly-developed method could make drug discovery faster, cheaper and more sustainable.

Straight-chain carbon compounds like fatty acids are some of the most commonly available chemicals in nature. On the other hand, many of the biologically-relevant organic compounds, including several drugs, have ring-shaped molecular structures. Scientists often go through a multi-step

E. EXPLAINED

Solving a problem in synthetic chemistry

Straight-chain carbon compounds such as fatty acids are some of the most commonly available chemicals in nature. On the other hand, many of the biologically-relevant organic compounds, including several drugs, have ring-shaped molecular structures. Scientists often go through a multi-step process to convert the fatty acids into more useful molecules. The new method solves this long-standing problem in synthetic chemistry.

process to convert the easily-available fatty acids into more useful molecules with a variety of applications.

In simple fatty acids, several carbon atoms are linked to each other in a long straight chain. Many of these carbon atoms are indistinguishable from each other. This makes it extremely difficult to chemically target any specific carbon atom in the

chain from where the sequence leading to ring formation could be initiated. Usually, multiple sites in the chain could be affected. Because of this, conversion could be achieved only through a long process involving multiple steps.

The research team at IIT Bombay, which included Maiti’s students Tanay Pal, Md Saimuddin Sk, Animesh Ghosh and Yazhinimuthu CM, was able to make a breakthrough with the development of a new chemical compound which proved to be crucial in the selective targeting of the desired carbon atom in the long chain. The use of this new chemical entity achieved the conversion in fewer steps, with much greater efficiency and significantly reduced chemical wastage. Somnath Kar from Bhabha Atomic Research Centre collaborated on the research.

Maiti told *The Indian Express* that the significance of the breakthrough lay in the fact that the method was not limited to conversion of any specific single molecule into a desired compound, but was a general process applicable to a wide array of organic compounds. “The method acts as a platform that can quickly convert simple saturated fatty acids into many

different bioactive molecules. This could help scientists study and improve compounds used in traditional medicine systems such as Ayurveda, and speed up their development into modern drugs,” he said.

In fact, researchers used their new method to synthesize more than 10 biologically and industrially relevant molecules that have applications in medicinal chemistry, chemical biology and the perfume and flavour industries. These included a molecule called muricatacin, which is naturally found in Laxman phal (sour-sop) and is believed to have anti-cancer properties. Extracting muricatacin from naturally-occurring substances is considered extremely difficult and inefficient. Only about 15 mg of muricatacin is obtained from about 15 kg of plant material, and that too is mixed with other substances, Maiti said.

The researchers were able to synthesize muricatacin in the laboratory in an easy and more efficient manner by converting other fatty acids. They were then able to modify this compound in such a manner that it exhibited anti-cancer properties comparable to muricatacin obtained from natural plants.

NEET-UG 2026 PAPER LEAK

111 of 136 questions on Latur tutor’s phone matched NTA master set, CBI tells Delhi court

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 15

THE CENTRAL Bureau of Investigation has submitted before a Delhi court that out of 136 handwritten questions recovered from the phone of an arrested Latur coaching centre owner, 111 matched the master question sets prepared by the National Testing Agency (NTA).

These questions were recovered from the cell phone of Shivraj Motegaonkar, who runs Renukai Chemistry Classes in Latur and a YouTube channel, Motegaonkar Sir’s RCC, with 1.68 lakh subscribers.

“Investigation has revealed that Aditya Motegaonkar ... attended special classes of co-accused P V Kulkarni where leaked Chemistry questions were provided, he prepared handwritten notes from those questions. During the search, in a mobile phone used by Shivraj Motegaonkar, 36 images (5 duplicate images) containing 132 handwritten questions of Chemistry purportedly in the handwriting of Shivraj Motegaonkar were found,” the CBI submitted before a Delhi court on Wednesday in reply to a bail plea filed by the accused.

“Prima facie, it was found

that approximately 111 of these questions match with questions in the NTA master question sets prepared for NEET UG 2026,” the CBI’s reply added.

As per the CBI, the date of capture of these questions was April 23, 2026 — almost two weeks before the NEET UG exam was held on May 3.

As per the agency, Motegaonkar obtained the questions on the premises of Siddhivinayak Hospital in Latur, run by city-based paediatrician Manoj Shirure. The CBI has claimed that the questions were allegedly leaked by NTA panel member and translator P V Kulkarni.

According to the CBI, the PDF files of the leaked question papers were sold through Telegram for Rs10 lakh. The CBI said a “guess paper” of 150 pages with 410 questions was circulated to some aspirants. Of those 410 questions, about 120 questions appeared in the chemistry paper of the exam. The “guess paper” was with students weeks before the examination, the agency has claimed. Till date, the agency has made 13 arrests in the case, including various teachers and students from Delhi, Jaipur, Gurgaon, Nashik, Pune, Latur, and Ahilyanagar.

Removing woman’s salwar, pressing chest do not amount to attempted rape: Patna HC

Himanshu Harsh
Patna July 15

HC held there was an “absence of any evidence of penetration... or any overt act unequivocally constituting an attempt to commit rape”

ATTEMPTING TO remove a woman’s salwar and pressing her chest does “not unequivocally establish” an attempt to rape, the Patna High Court has held while setting aside the conviction of a man accused of attempting to sexually assault a client inside his photography studio.

Acquitting the appellant on July 9, the court held that the prosecution failed to prove the allegations, observing that even if its case were accepted “in its entirety”, it would, “at best”, make out an offence of assault or criminal force intended to outrage a woman’s modesty under Section 354 of the IPC. Justice Purnendu Singh allowed the appeal of Himanshu Kumar Pathak alias Mithiya Pathak against his 2013 conviction by an Additional Sessions Judge in Banka.

The trial court had convicted Pathak under Sections 376/511 IPC and 342 IPC, sentencing him to three years’ rigorous imprisonment for the former offence along with a fine of Rs5,000, and six months’ imprisonment for wrongful confinement. The sentences were to run concurrently.

According to the prosecution, the incident took place on

January 19, 2008, when the complainant accompanied her father to a photo studio in Amarapur for a photograph. It alleged that the accused, who owned the studio, asked her father to remain outside on the pretext of viewing the photograph on a computer, bolted the studio door, attempted to remove the woman’s salwar, undressed himself and physically molested her. The woman raised an alarm, following which her father forced open the door and the accused allegedly fled. An FIR was registered the next day.

The HC noted that the prosecution examined five witnesses — the victim, her parents, a formal investigating officer and an independent witness who turned hostile. It also noted that the investigating officer who completed the probe was not examined during the

trial and no medical officer was produced to prove any medical evidence.

On the merits, the HC held that there was an “absence of any evidence of penetration, even to the slightest extent, or any overt act unequivocally constituting an attempt to commit rape”, and therefore the ingredients of Sections 375 and 376 read with Section 511 IPC were not attracted.

The court observed that the appellant was alleged to have confined the victim inside the studio, closed the door, attempted to remove her salwar and physically molested her by pressing her chest. According to the judgment, “these acts clearly establish the use of criminal force upon a woman with the intention, or at least the knowledge, that such acts were likely to outrage her modesty, thereby satisfying the essential ingredients of Section 354 IPC.”

The judgment held that “even if the prosecution case is accepted in its entirety, the acts attributed to the appellant... do not unequivocally establish the commission of an offence punishable under Section 376(1) read with Section 511 of the IPC. At best, the allegations disclose an act intended to outrage the modesty of the victim, thereby attracting the ingredients of Section 354 IPC.”

People losing sleep in big cities due to high night-time temperatures: Study

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, July 15

People in some of India’s largest cities are losing between 65 and 93 hours of sleep each year because of climate change-induced increases in night-time temperatures, a new study has revealed.

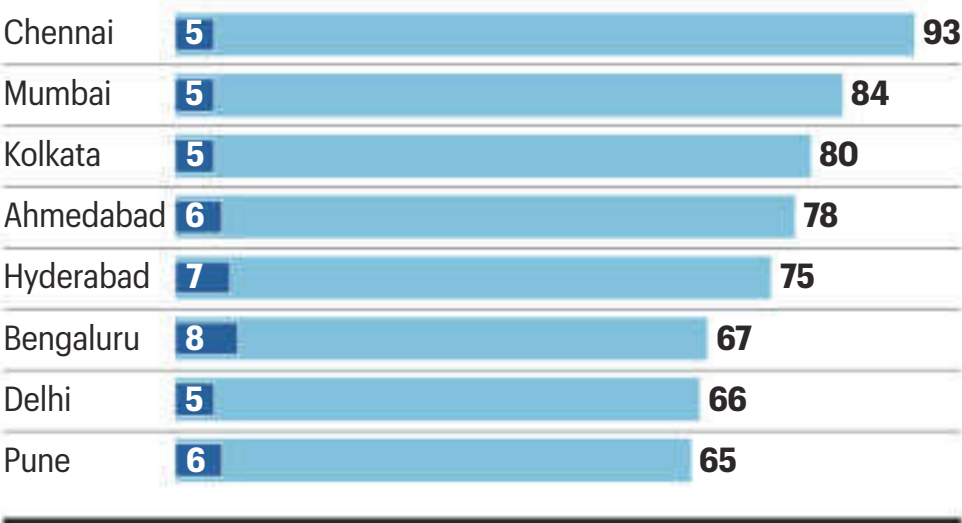
Chennai was found to be the city with highest overall sleep loss in India, with residents losing an average of 93 hours of sleep annually, of which five hours could be directly attributable to climate change, according to the study by Climate Central, a US-based climate advocacy group. Residents of Mumbai and Kolkata are losing 84 and 80 hours of sleep respectively every year, the study said.

The study used an already-established relationship between night-time temperatures and sleep to assess loss of sleeping hours in more than 1,300 cities across the world.

It found that an average person in these cities lost nearly 56 hours of sleep per year in the

• Sleep Loss Across Major Cities (2020–2025)

- Sleep Loss (Hours/person/year) attributable to climate change
- Total Sleep Loss (Hours/person/year)



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

2020-2025 time period because of unusually high night-time temperatures.

At least 10 per cent of this sleep loss could be directly attributed to human-induced climate change.

Unusually high night-time temperatures has emerged as a major concern in recent years, and the cause of many heat-related deaths. High temperatures at night prevent the

human bodies from cooling down and recover from the heat stress experienced during the day, leading to loss of energy, discomfort and lack of productivity during day time. It is also a health hazard, increasing the risk of strokes and other cardiovascular conditions. Short and poor-quality sleep can also shorten life expectancy and increase the risk of accidents and injuries.

Due to climate change, night-time temperatures have increased at a faster rate compared to day-time temperatures across the world.

“Many people have been experiencing hotter summer nights, making it harder for the body to cool down before sleep. As a result, sleep quality suffers, which can lead to irritability, mental and physical fatigue. People living with chronic health conditions are particularly vulnerable to these effects,” Abhiyant Tiwari, lead, climate resilience and health at the Natural Resources Defence Council (NRDC), an environmental advocacy group, said.

The study included over 100 Indian cities, and found substantial losses in sleeping hours everywhere. Delhi and Chandigarh were among the cities where the sleep loss was the lowest, about 67 and 62 hours every year. Bengaluru happened to be the city where the footprint of climate change was observed to be the highest, about 12 per cent of the 67 hours lost every year.



America's hubris has yielded a dramatically more dangerous world

THE RESUMPTION of the Iran war, with a dramatic escalation of tit-for-tat military operations, has laid bare the realities of modern warfare. In hindsight, perhaps the US was itching to show the world that the MoU that inaugurated the truce was not the strategic disaster it was widely perceived to be. After all, the invading coalition launched "Epic Fury", premised on overwhelming force and decisive transformation, but the military campaign was regarded as an Epic Failure — a textbook example of how muddled objectives, fundamental misreading of adversaries, and alienation of international partners caused the offensive to boomerang on its orchestrators.

Rather than executing the regime change that was rashly announced as the principal objective, the war paradoxically fortified the targeted nation, expanded its geopolitical prestige, and left the international coalition pausing the conflict on significantly worse terms than when it began. The volatile 60-day negotiation framework that officially commenced on June 15, when US Vice President J D Vance and Iranian Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf signed a 14-point MoU, has collapsed, though peace talks are being attempted in Oman. Still, the war underscored the severe limitations of coercive military power in an era where asymmetric capabilities can disrupt global superpower superiority.

The primary turning point that shattered the coalition's military calculus was the sudden and highly effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz. For all the technological prowess brought to bear by Western forces, naval and military planners quickly discovered that in an era dominated by low-cost drone warfare, re-establishing total control over a critical maritime chokepoint is a challenging endeavour once an adversary has

laid mines offshore and prepared its defences. By leveraging a simple yet far-reaching deterrent, the defending nation successfully held the global economy hostage, forcing a desperate rush toward diplomacy.

The resulting MoU, in exchange for merely returning to the status quo ante and allowing shipping lanes to reopen temporarily, granted sweeping concessions, including massive phased sanctions relief, Iranian export of over 40 million barrels of oil, the unfreezing of tens of billions of dollars in foreign assets, and the establishment of a historic multinational reconstruction fund, while details of the nuclear deal remain unclear. All this could have been achieved at the negotiating table without resort to war and without devastating the world economy. A core demand of the invasion, the eradication of Iran's ballistic-missile capacity, was omitted from the MoU, leaving the invaders to crow about reopening a waterway that was not even closed before their war began.

The humiliating MoU starkly contrasts with Barack Obama's JCPOA, scrapped by Donald Trump in 2018, which restricted Iran's nuclear capacity without a single bomb being dropped. By replacing nuanced diplomacy and international verification with reckless bombardment, the US removed the primary mechanisms of international oversight. Renewed bombing gives Iran a compelling incentive to rapidly accelerate toward full nuclear weapon status.

After all, developing nuclear capacity attracted attacks; but North Korea actually has nukes, and is handled with kid gloves. Lesson: Get the bomb!

The collapse of diplomatic negotiations is due to the continuing Hormuz dispute. Flushed with its regional leverage, Iran attempted to institute a unilateral security



SHASHI THAROOR

mechanism to extract mandatory shipping transit fees from commercial vessels. This move has been firmly rejected by most of the world, who cite international freedom of navigation to block such extortionate demands over a natural waterway. (The Panama and Suez Canals are man-made and charge for services; straits like Hormuz or Malacca require no human intervention and are recognised in international law as global commons.) Iranian attacks on vessels attempting to evade the tolls provoked the latest US attacks, and now the renewed US blockade. The US charging tolls — a threat that Trump has now backed away from — is as unwelcome as the Iranians doing so.

The US retaliatory attacks have targeted coastal surveillance, air defence networks, drone and missile storage infrastructure, and logistics hubs (including tactical railway corridors and bridges) along Iran's southern coast to blunt its capability to obstruct maritime traffic. Iran immediately responded with a coordinated wave of drone and ballistic missile attacks against US bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and Jordan.

The strategic failure has also exposed the fallacy of leadership decapitation. While initial strikes successfully targeted and eliminated high-ranking political and military figures, the entrenched institutional structure of the Iranian state proved remarkably resilient. Rather than inducing moderation or domestic collapse, the systematic assassination of the ruling elite simply

cleared the path for a new, younger generation of leaders who are demonstrably more radical, fiercely angry, more sophisticated, and committed to regional dominance.

The economic ripple effects of this miscalculation extend far beyond the immediate combat zones, inflicting a ruinous toll on

the Global South. Iran estimates that the conflict has set back its economy by roughly \$200 billion, but energy-dependent nations like India have been hit almost as severely. As the conflict choked off regional trade, skyrocketing oil prices and rampant inflation severely strained fiscal balances, driving up import costs and weakening the rupee, compromising the economic security of millions who had nothing to do with the war.

The international community's endorsement of an integrated ceasefire across multiple fronts (and the MoU's failure to end regional proxy funding) had effectively formalised Iran's right to intervene politically and militarily in neighbouring states to protect proxies like Hezbollah, Hamas, and the Houthis. This is another reality the resumed attacks seek to undo.

Washington realises the conflict has severely diminished the geopolitical authority and credibility of the superpower that initiated it. Hence Trump's threat that 1,000 US missiles remain "locked and loaded" for immediate unleashing. Domestically, the architects of the war face intense public backlash for failing to deliver on promises of rapid peacemaking and minimal inflation, while internationally, global actors increasingly view the US not as a stable anchor but as an unpredictable risk to the global equilibrium. The disastrous current situation serves as a stark historical warning that military hubris, when detached from coherent objectives and historical reality, inevitably yields a fractured international order, severely compromised allies, and a dramatically more dangerous world.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

Australian uranium fuels next phase in India's n-programme



MANPREET SETHI



BHAWNA BUDHWAR

Consensus on the safeguards-related procedures governing the tracking of uranium was achieved after two years of intensive negotiations. This signals renewed hope that Australian uranium will make its way to India once commercial contracts are in place

COMMON SECURITY concerns have made Australia and India discover a new relevance for their relationship. This was reflected in the forward-looking joint statement that came out of the two countries' recent summit. It lists many areas of cooperation, but what stands out is movement on uranium supplies from Australia to India's nuclear power programme.

Historically, Australia has maintained a strict policy of exporting uranium only to signatories of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT). Canberra had frowned when India, a non-NPT member, concluded the nuclear cooperation agreement with the USA in 2008 and subsequently was exceptionalised by the Nuclear Suppliers Group to source uranium, nuclear equipment, technology and reactors from the international market. Australia's change of heart is good news. It holds the world's largest uranium reserves, approximately one-third of the global total. And the quality of Australian uranium far outstrips India's low-grade mineral, which exacts higher extraction costs and generates significant tailings that need to be safely managed to protect human health and the environment.

India's consistent non-proliferation credentials facilitated the shift in the Australian position. This began once India signed an Additional Protocol (AP) with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) in 2009, committing itself to a "separation plan" that bifurcated its nuclear facilities into civilian and military. India safeguarded its strategic autonomy while meeting the non-proliferation requirements of international civilian nuclear cooperation. Once the AP came into force in 2014, an Australia-India Nuclear Cooperation Agreement was concluded in 2015 to enable uranium exports.

However, commercial uranium exports did not start immediately because an Administrative Arrangement (AA) to implement the agreement had to be operationalised in Australia. This had to establish the practical procedures for tracking, accounting and reporting the use of Australian Obligated Nuclear Material (AONM), ensuring that the imported uranium would be used exclusively for peaceful civilian purposes in

accordance with the bilateral agreement and IAEA safeguards. Consensus on the safeguards-related procedures governing the tracking of uranium was achieved after two years of intensive negotiations. This signals renewed hope that Australian uranium will make its way to India once commercial contracts are in place. Since 2008-09, India has been importing natural uranium ore concentrate from Canada, France, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan and natural uranium dioxide pellets and enriched uranium from Russia. With the availability of Australian uranium, the kitty would further expand.

These developments are the building blocks for India's nuclear energy expansion, which aims to increase installed nuclear power capacity from 8.78 GW to 100 GW by 2047. To achieve this, the government has a two-pronged approach. One, a "fleet mode" expansion of large reactors led by India's nuclear operator, the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL). By itself and in partnership with NTPC, NPCIL is engaged in the construction of several 700 MWe indigenous nuclear reactors, with more to follow. Two, the government is supporting the research and development of low-carbon small modular reactors for energy-guzzlers such as steel/cement plants or AI data centres. The necessary legislative and regulatory changes have been effected through the SHANTI Act. The government will continue to control strategic and security-sensitive segments of the nuclear fuel cycle.

Keeping in view the planned large-scale expansion of all reactor sizes, India is pursuing a strategy to build a strategic uranium reserve to guard against supply-chain disruptions that may be caused by black swan events like pandemics or the eruption of geopolitical hotspots. A new enthusiasm has gripped the nuclear power sector. While the government assures access to nuclear fuel, the nascent private industry must imbibe the highest standards of safety, security and safeguards. NPCIL will have to do the hand-holding to enable India to write a new chapter of its nuclear story.

Sethi is distinguished fellow and Budhwar is research associate, Centre for Aerospace Power and Strategic Studies

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JULY 16, 2026

One Nation, One Election will not fix what is broken

VIJAY KELKAR
AND AJIT RANADE

INDIA'S PARLIAMENT is set to take up the Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill to synchronise Lok Sabha and all state assembly elections, inserting a new Article 82A and amending Articles 83 and 172. The Bill requires a two-thirds majority in both Houses and ratification by half the states. After a High-Level Committee (HLC) chaired by former President Ram Nath Kovind, the government has committed to this push. The scale of the constitutional intervention demands rigorous scrutiny of the claimed benefits.

The HLC report rests on four pillars: Cost savings, relief from "policy paralysis" caused by the Model Code of Conduct, reduced burden on government manpower, and an economic growth dividend. Its economic anchor is a striking claim: Research by Prachi Mishra, N K Singh and colleagues finds that real GDP growth is approximately 1.5 percentage points higher following simultaneous election cycles. That single finding must be examined carefully.

The paper compares the simultaneous election era (1952–1967, partially until the mid-1980s) with the subsequent asynchronous period. But before reaching for the econometrics, consider the plain historical record. The era produced what economists call the "Hindu rate of growth": Around 3.5 per cent annually, decades of the licence raj, import substitution, and a closed economy. India's genuine high-growth era came entirely under asynchronous elections: The 8 to 9 per cent annual growth of 2003–2011 was achieved with staggered state polls running through every single year. If simultaneous elections drive growth, this history is very difficult to explain. The macro confounders — trade liberalisation, the IT boom, global capital flows, financial deepening, and the 1991 reforms — are too large to control away. More consequentially, the paper's own results show the growth effect operating partly through higher fiscal deficits and greater

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

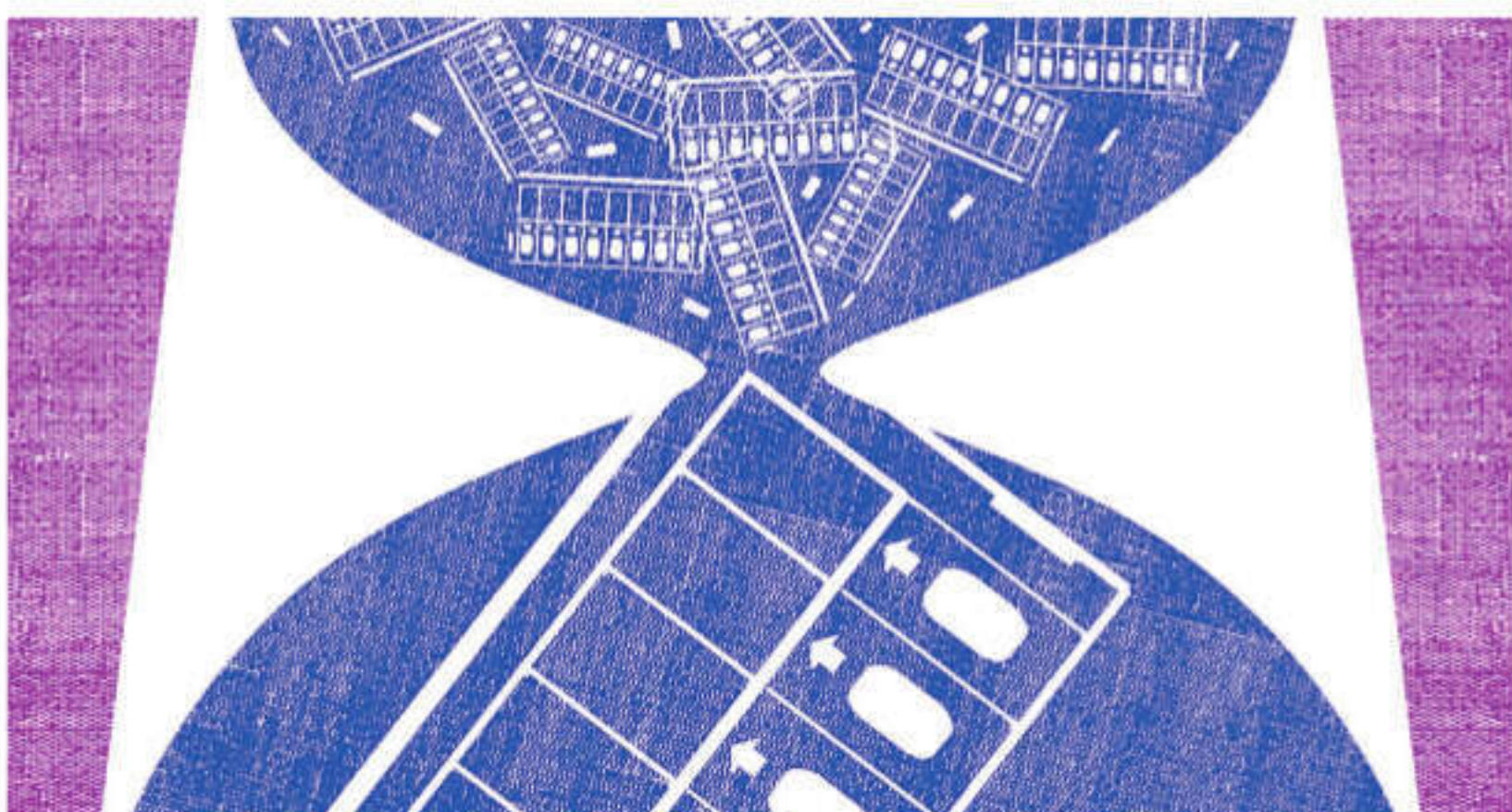


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

government spending: Structural improvement, or a political business cycle merely compressed in time? A constitutional overhaul cannot rest on correlations that India's own history contradicts.

On costs, the argument collapses once you ask a simple question: Who is actually spending? The government's election expenditure is not even 0.1 per cent of its own budget, as ECI accounts confirm. The "excessive" spending is by candidates and parties. But the telling detail is this: Per audited accounts submitted to the ECI, the average official expenditure by candidates is 50 per cent of the permissible ceiling. Candidates are, on paper, underspending, not overspending. The implication is inescapable: The real money is not in any account. It is black money, unaccounted and untraceable, which the Centre for Media Studies estimates at over Rs 1,00,000 crore for the 2024 Lok Sabha election alone. No electoral calendar reform can touch this. The same political economy of cash, patronage and opacity prevails whether elections happen every year or once in five years. ONOE does not reduce election spending; it merely concentrates it.

On the Model Code of Conduct: The MCC restricts government announcements for roughly 45 to 60 days per election. Because India holds state elections in a rolling fashion, NITI Aayog estimates

some part of the country is under the MCC for about four months every year. Under ONOE, that rolling freeze becomes a single national freeze every five years, simultaneously halting developmental announcements across every state. The disruption is not eliminated; it is nationally concentrated and potentially more distorting. Calling this "policy paralysis" mistakes democratic restraint for administrative dysfunction.

The deeper objections are constitutional. The Supreme Court in *Kesavananda Bharati* has held that parliamentary democracy and free and fair elections are part of the Constitution's basic structure, a threshold even amendments cannot cross. Three specific tensions arise. First, parliamentary government rests on collective responsibility: The executive holds office only so long as it commands legislative confidence. Under ONOE, a government losing its majority would either continue without a legitimate mandate or trigger President's Rule — neither is acceptable. The HLC's proposed "constructive no-confidence motion", requiring any no-confidence vote to be paired with a simultaneous confidence vote for an alternative, is borrowed from Germany and distorts India's parliamentary tradition. As Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy researchers point out, it would incentivise minority governments to cling to office despite lacking popular support.

These require targeted reform:
Mandatory disclosure of all donations, enforceable expenditure limits, disbarment of criminally tainted candidates, and a genuinely autonomous Election Commission

Second, reaching the first synchronised cycle requires extending or curtailing multiple state assembly terms. Articles 83 and 172 deliberately use the words "no longer" — a phrase the Constituent Assembly inserted to bar extensions beyond five years. Extending terms without fresh mandate breaches the voters' contract; curtailing them denies voters the period they voted for. Either way, the electorate's will is overridden.

Third, simultaneous elections structurally disadvantage regional parties, and the republic's federal character. Research shows a consistent "wave effect" when national and state elections coincide. Voters tend to choose the same party at both levels, giving large national parties a decisive advantage. Regional concerns such as agrarian distress in Vidarbha, coastal livelihoods in Kerala, or flood management in Assam, find parliamentary voice through regional formations. Bundling elections risks submerging these voices under national campaigns.

The ONOE framework also ignores elections to India's constitutionally protected third tier of government. The 73rd and 74th Amendments placed panchayat and urban local body elections under State Election Commissions, not the ECI, guaranteeing their autonomy. These are not minor contests. Mumbai, Pune and Bengaluru have budgets larger than many Indian states, and their elections are high-stakes political battles. Folding them into ONOE would violate the spirit of these amendments; keeping them separate undermines ONOE's own rationale. Substantial expenditure, security deployment, and governance disruption would continue through every panchayat and municipal cycle, leaving the claimed savings largely illusory.

What makes this particularly dispiriting is that the genuine pathologies of elections go untouched: Unlimited party spending, cash distribution to voters, criminalisation of politics, and misuse of state machinery. These require targeted reform: Mandatory disclosure of all donations, enforceable expenditure limits, disbarment of criminally tainted candidates, and a genuinely autonomous ECI. All these reforms are achievable without touching the Constitution's federal and parliamentary foundations.

The ONOE Bill reorganises the democratic calendar. It does not fix what is broken.

The writers are respectively, vice president and senior fellow, Pune International Centre

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2rVd_RGf9mljMzg1

A law to give women farmers their due

SOUMYA SWAMINATHAN
AND DEVENDRA FADNAVIS

MAHARASHTRA HAS become the first state to enact a law for the empowerment of women farmers. The Maharashtra Women Farmers Empowerment Act, 2026 is a path-breaking initiative. Women across the globe do much of the work across agrifood systems from production to processing, yet their contributions are not recognised. They face challenges in access to credit, insurance, extension services, technology and markets. Government benefits are often linked to land ownership, usually held by men. It is against this backdrop that 2026 is being observed as the International Year of the Woman Farmer, calling for "fairer, more inclusive and sustainable agrifood systems for all."

Maharashtra is a state that has long shaped India's social reform movements with stalwarts like Savitribai Phule, Mahatma Jyotiba Phule, Maharshi Karve, Pandita Ramabai, Lokahitwadi Gopal Hari Deshmukh and Gopal Ganesh Agarkar working tirelessly for women's rights and gender equality. The state has also seen positive interventions in recent times. The Fourth Policy for Women, 2024 commits to facilitating gender-inclusive agriculture development, including "access to, control over, and ownership of land and other productive assets, as well as access to entitlements" and "enhancing the role of women in decision-making and control over agricultural income".

A large majority (82 per cent) of the rural female workforce in Maharashtra is employed in agriculture as compared to 58 per cent of rural men, according to the Periodic Labour Force Survey, 2025. (The corresponding all-India figures are 73 per cent and 47 per cent respectively). However, less than a fifth of operational landholdings are in the names of women. Late last year, the Government of Maharashtra embarked on the groundwork to give shape to a law for the empowerment of women farmers. The M S Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF) has been a partner in this effort, together with the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy (Maharashtra).

Women farmers engaged in different agricultural and allied activities, civil society organisations and networks, bankers, lawyers, researchers and frontline government officials have all participated in the consultations. A special session was organised jointly with the state legislature on the occasion of International Women's Day. Following this, a committee was constituted to draft the Bill, which was presented and discussed at regional consultations. The feedback and suggestions received contributed to giving a final shape to the Bill that was presented in the Legislative Assembly after the cabinet's approval.

The Act adopts a broad definition of "agriculture" and "farmer" in line with the National Policy for Farmers (2007), and includes any person who is engaged in crop husbandry, animal husbandry, poultry, fishery, agro-forestry, vermiculture, mushroom cultivation, and primary processing, either as owner or labourer. A woman engaged in any of these activities can apply for a Woman Farmer Certificate (WFC) either to the gram sabha or nagar panchayat. This certificate will formally recognise the woman as a farmer and effectively de-links the requirement of owning land. Going forward, the WFC will give women farmers greater access to entitlements under government schemes, extension services, credit and market opportunities. It will help the government design gender-responsive schemes for skill development and provide targeted support for single women farmers.

A digital registry of women farmers backed by a special fund, a state level empowerment cell and designated officers at district and sub-district levels will facilitate the implementation of the law. A state-level monitoring committee headed by the chief secretary will facilitate coordination and ensure effective implementation. A governing council headed by the chief minister will provide guidance and oversee the implementation.

This landmark law is an important first step towards social change to address deeply entrenched inequalities in access to land, water and other natural resources. The increasing migration of men in search of employment is leaving women to shoulder the responsibility of food and nutrition security in the midst of the growing challenge of climate change and depleting natural resources. It is globally observed that women are among the strongest drivers of adaptation to climate change. Proactive policy support will enable them to play this role even better as we work together for inclusive and sustainable agrifood systems.

Swaminathan is chairperson, M S Swaminathan Research Foundation, and Fadnavis is Chief Minister, Maharashtra



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

• POLICY

Green energy push, 7.5-GW capacity target: Gujarat’s data centre policy

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, July 15

THE GUJARAT government last week announced a data centre policy for 2026-29, targeting investments of Rs 6 lakh crore and the creation of 7.5 gigawatts (GW) of capacity, which it says would be the highest in the country.

The policy lays out a wide range of incentives for investors, including duty and tax exemptions, relief in Floor Space Index (FSI), uninterrupted water and power supply and relaxations in building norms.

The Viksit Gujarat Data Center Policy (2026-29) follows Reliance Industries Ltd’s announcement last month of a partnership with Meta to lease its first AI-enabled data centre in India, at Jamnagar in Gujarat.

Telangana was the first state in the country to announce a data centre policy in 2016, followed by Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Odisha, Maharashtra, Haryana and Andhra Pradesh.

Stress on green energy

Gujarat has claimed that its policy is among the most ambitious state-level frameworks for hyperscale, AI-ready data centres, with a strong emphasis on green energy.

The policy aims to enable the establishment of up to 7.5 GW of data centre capacity. Under the policy, a data centre entity must ensure that at least 51% of the electricity consumed for core operations comes from green and renewable sources.

This comes amid a larger push for green energy in the industry. Google has announced plans to build an AI data centre campus in Andhra Pradesh powered entirely by clean energy. The Adani Group has announced a 5 GW data centre platform across India through its AdaniConneX joint venture, which will be powered by the Adani Green Energy park at Khavda in Kutch district. P Bharathi, Secretary of Gujarat’s Department of Science and Technology (DST), told *The Indian Express*: “Gujarat is the first state to announce the largest capacity (hyperscale) data center as well as the first to have a dedicated policy in the country specifically designed for green AI data centres. More importantly, other states are working on a case-to-case basis and not under a dedicated policy like Gujarat.”

DHOLERA CALLING

- The state government is looking to attract data centres to the Dholera region, 100 km south-west of Ahmedabad.
- To do this, the government has offered a capital subsidy of 2.5% on eligible fixed capital investment. This includes core technical and infra expenses but excludes the cost of land, land development and chips.

Financial incentives

The Gujarat government has offered to exempt stamp duty and registration fee for leasing or buying land. It has also offered 100% reimbursement of electricity duty for 20 years and a subsidy at the rate of Re 1 per unit of power consumed by a data centre entity for 20 years, both starting from the date of commencement of commercial operations. The policy provides full reimbursement of eligible expenses on plant and machinery, building infrastructure and services for up to 20 years. It offers financial assistance for desalination plants to meet the sector’s high water requirements.

• GOVERNANCE

Ladakh’s 7 councils & the decentralisation debate



DEEPTIMAN TIWARY

THE LADAKH administration’s decision to constitute Autonomous Hill Development Councils (AHDCs) in the Union Territory’s seven districts has reopened a debate over how political power should be distributed in the region.

While the administration says the move will deepen grassroots governance, the two civil society groups negotiating with the Centre — the Apex Body, Leh (ABL) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) — argue it could weaken the representative political structure they demand under Article 371. The disagreement also reflects a widening trust deficit between Ladakh’s leadership and the Centre since the region became a Union Territory in 2019.

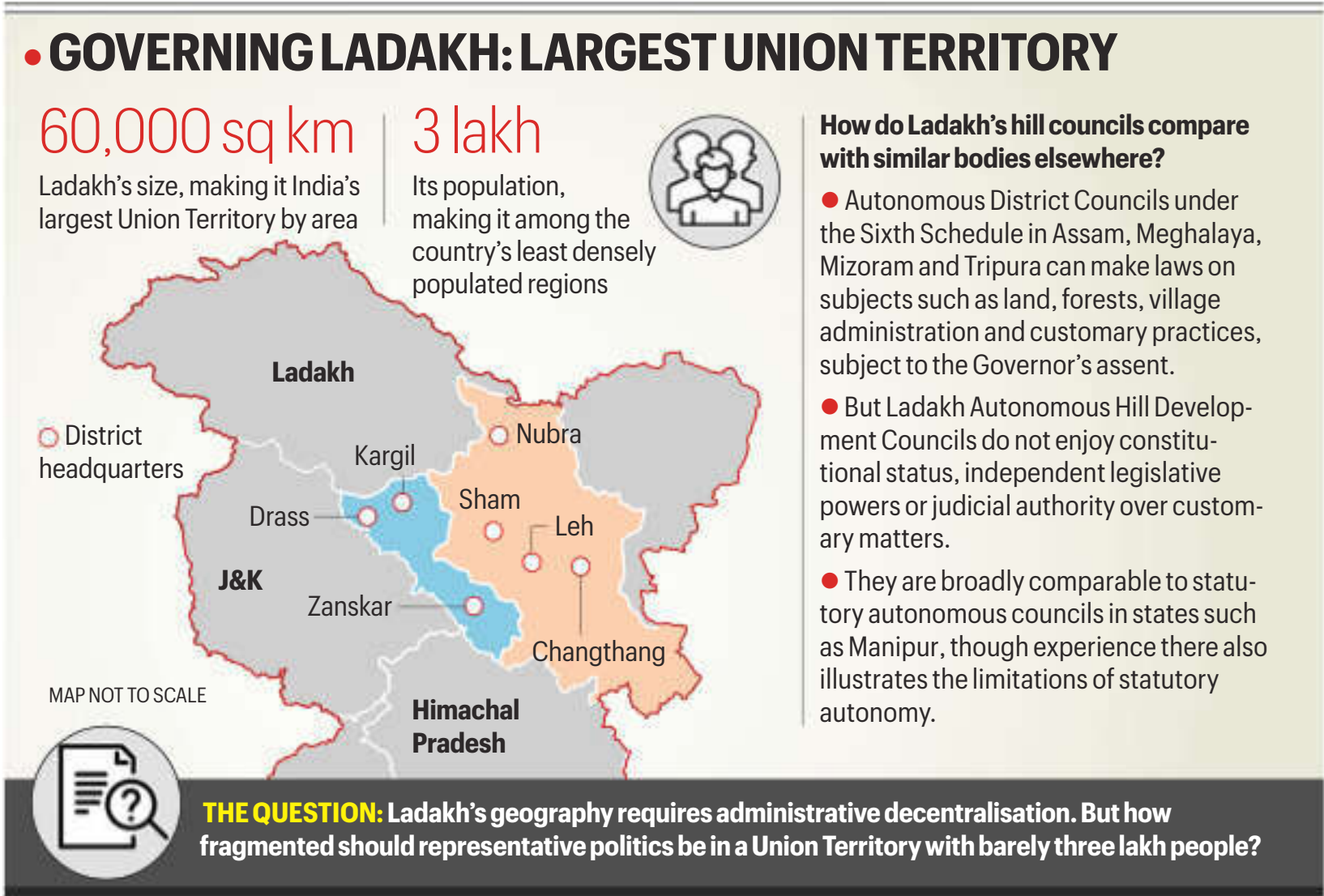
What has the administration announced?

On Monday, the Ladakh administration announced that an Autonomous Hill Development Council would be constituted in each of the Union Territory’s seven districts. Until now, such councils existed only in Leh and Kargil. The move follows the creation of five new districts — Drass, Sham, Nubra, Changthang and Zaskar — in April.

Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra said the new councils represented “a major step towards democratic decentralisation”. He also said discussions with the Centre had broadly agreed on creating a Union Territory-level representative body under a customised framework under Article 371, which would exercise legislative, executive, financial and administrative powers.

The administration argues that the two initiatives are complementary. Section 3 of the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council Act provides for the constitution of a council in every district, and officials say the creation of seven districts logically necessitates seven councils.

The government also points to Ladakh’s unique geography. Spread across nearly 60,000 sq km but home to barely 3 lakh people, it is India’s largest Union Territory by area and among its least densely populated regions. Many villages are separated



by mountain passes and several hours of travel, making decentralised administration a longstanding demand.

Why are Ladakh’s civil society groups opposing the move?

Neither the ABL nor the KDA disputes the need for decentralised administration. Their objection is to what they call the fragmentation of political authority at a time when negotiations are underway over a representative political framework for Ladakh.

ABL co-chairman Chherring Dorje Lakruk argues that empowering seven district councils could leave little meaningful authority with the proposed representative body under Article 371. “This is a plan to dilute the powers of the proposed representative government that is going to take shape under Article 371. If all the powers are going to be given to the hill councils, what will the representative government do?” he told *The Indian Express*.

KDA co-chairman Sajjad Kargili termed the move “maximum government and minimum governance”, questioning how seven councils would improve governance when, according to him, even the existing councils have steadily lost powers.

Civil society leaders argue that once seven hill councils, Panchayati Raj institutions,

Procedure problem

According to Ladakh leaders, the proposal for 7 hill councils figured in the Minutes of the May 22 meeting. They refused to sign that version, after which a revised record, without the proposal, was signed.

They now argue the Centre went ahead with the announcement without consulting them.

tions, the Union Territory administration and a future Article 371 representative body all coexist, the lines of political accountability may become blurred. “With so few people and so many representative institutions, what meaningful role will eventually remain for the territorial government? And where does Panchayati Raj fit into this?” said a Ladakh leader associated with the negotiations.

Their opposition has also been sharpened by procedure. According to Ladakh leaders, the proposal for seven hill councils figured in the Minutes of the May 22 meeting between the Centre and Ladakh representatives. They refused to sign that version, after which a revised record, without the proposal, was prepared and signed. They now argue the Centre has proceeded with the announcement without consulting them.

Why such distrust?

The initial enthusiasm following Union Territory status gave way to disappointment after it became clear that, unlike Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh would not have a legislature. Negotiations over Sixth Schedule-like safeguards and later an Article 371 framework have moved slowly, with civil society leaders accusing the Centre of delaying substantive political reforms.

Relations deteriorated after the September 2025 violence during protests in Leh, the detention of climate activist Sonam Wangchuk under the National Security Act, and remarks by political leaders that were interpreted locally as questioning Ladakh’s patriotism. The mistrust deepened when the Voice of Buddhist Ladakh emerged claiming to represent Buddhist interests. ABL leaders alleged the organisation had been encouraged to weaken the joint movement of Leh and Kargil — an allegation the administration denies.

The creation of five new districts in April triggered another controversy, with the KDA alleging that the new administrative map disproportionately favoured Buddhist-majority districts.

What powers do the hill councils have, and how functional are they?

On paper, the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils are among the more powerful statutory district bodies in India, if territorial authorities under the Sixth Schedule are kept out.

The 1997 Act makes them responsible for district planning and development, preparation of budgets and district plans, implementation of development schemes, management of land vested in the councils, collection of certain local taxes and functioning as the district planning and development board. In practice, however, political leaders across party lines say the councils have steadily lost relevance after Ladakh became a Union Territory.

Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in LAHDC-Leh, Tsering Namgyal, told *The Indian Express* last year that decision-making had shifted to the Lieutenant Governor’s secretariat and departmental secretaries, with councils often excluded. He said council recommendations on land were frequently ignored, council staff were increasingly deployed for the UT administration, and budgets had been reduced.

Lakruk similarly described the councils as “virtually defunct”, alleging that even where the law gives councils authority over land, recommendations often remain pending with the district administration and elected representatives are bypassed.

The paradox, therefore, is that while the administration now proposes expanding the number of hill councils from two to seven, many elected representatives argue that the existing councils themselves first need to be made genuinely functional.

• ECONOMY

India-UK FTA kicks in: What changes for consumers and industry

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 15

AMID A fracturing world trade order, the India-UK free trade agreement (FTA) came into effect on Wednesday. The deal, negotiated over four years and marked by major political volatility in London, is India’s first comprehensive deal with a developed country. The deal laid the framework for India’s negotiations with the European Union.

With the deal, India’s labour-intensive goods exports, such as textiles, footwear and gems and jewellery, could get a boost. Indian consumers can access British cars, scotch and chocolates at lower prices. India has reduced tariffs on around 90% of products and the UK has eliminated tariffs on 99% of Indian exports.

Changes for consumers

For the first time, India has given major concessions to imported cars and alcoholic beverages in an FTA, reducing tariffs for British cars from up to 110% to 30% in year one. The duty will go down to 10% by year five of the deal coming into effect. The

nual quota for British cars starts at 20,000 vehicles and peaks at 37,000 by year five.

India has also given major concessions to British alcoholic beverages by reducing tariff from 150% to 75% initially and then to 40% by year 10. According to Delhi-based thinktank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), this is a major concession as India is one of the world’s largest and fastest-growing spirits markets and the UK is the world’s largest whisky exporter.

Indian textile exports currently face tariffs of up to 10% in the UK. The trade deal could place India on a more level playing field with competitors such as Bangladesh, thereby boosting exports. India’s gems & jewellery exports, along with footwear exports, will also get a boost as duty in the UK has been eliminated from up to 12% and 16% respectively.

Customs changes

For the first time in an FTA, India has allowed a system of self-declaration of origin by exporters or producers in the United Kingdom, replacing the conventional system of certificates issued by designated

More choices, lower prices

- Indian consumers can access British cars, scotch and chocolates at lower prices.
- Tariffs for British beauty and cosmetics and sports equipment have also been removed or reduced.

authorities, which often causes delays and hurdles. Experts said this could become the custom norm for exporters in developed countries such as the EU and US, making it comparatively easier for them to ship goods to India.

This customs change comes as India is also aiming to reduce its dependence on Chinese and Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) exporters.

India’s dependence on Chinese medical devices has been a concern. Now, New Delhi has removed up to 14% tariffs on the UK’s medical devices, with phased tariff reductions for some sensitive items.

Quota on steel exports

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal at a press briefing said quotas allocated by the UK will ensure that India’s iron and steel exports go up. A government official said India’s iron and steel exports will grow from around \$850 million to over \$1 billion.

The curbs on steel imports announced by the UK after the trade negotiations had become a major flash point before the deal came into effect.

Concessions for professionals

The Commerce and Industry Ministry said that the deal on social security contributions would benefit 75,000 Indian Professionals and around 900 firms by providing exemption from contribution to UK National Insurance for five years. It covers the most important element of avoiding double contribution, exempting employees of Indian companies in the UK from contributing to the UK system.

The challenges

A commerce and industry ministry official said the labour and environment chapter of the India-UK agreement is not binding. Experts said this is a big win for India, as western countries have strong labour and environment norms that tend to act as a non-tariff barrier for exports from developing nations. However, India did not get an exemption from the UK’s proposed Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (a pricing framework to ensure imported carbon-intensive goods face a carbon cost comparable to domestic products), which come into effect from January 1 next year.

• GLOBAL

In China’s new ballistic missile test, the worries for Indo-Pacific region



EXPERT EXPLAINS

SUYASH DESAI
POLITICAL SCIENTIST AND NON-RESIDENT FELLOW WITH THE FOREIGN POLICY RESEARCH INSTITUTE, PHILADELPHIA

CHINA TESTED its sea-based long-range intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM) last week (July 6), marking its first-ever test of a submarine-based ballistic missile in international waters. This is the People’s Liberation Army’s (PLA) second launch of a ballistic missile in international waters since 1980. China conducted a land-based ICBM test on September 21, 2024.

The latest test missile was reportedly launched from a submarine in the South China Sea. It was carrying a dummy war-

head that covered a distance of 7,300 km, reportedly flying over the Philippines, before landing in the Southern Pacific Ocean. The dummy warhead landed within an area designated under the Treaty of Rarotonga’s South Pacific nuclear-free zone (where testing or stationing of nuclear explosive devices is barred), after it flew over the Exclusive Economic Zones of Micronesia, Nauru, Kiribati and Tuvalu.

What is known about this missile test?

It is difficult to determine if the missile was Ju Lang 2 (JL-2) or the latest Ju Lang 3 (JL-3). Both JL-2 and JL-3 are submarine-launched ICBMs, jointly developed with DF-31 and DF-41, respectively. ICBMs generally have a range of at least 5,000 km, and the JL-2 is capable of travelling 8,000-9,000 km. The JL-3 reportedly has a range of over 9,000 km. Both delivery systems can be paired with China’s Type 094 SSBNs (nuclear-powered submarines with ballistic missiles).

Why is Beijing testing now?

Since the turn of the decade, and especially in the past two years, Beijing has



The ICBM being tested on July 6. X/@MND_CHINA

not shied away from overtly tomming its improving nuclear capabilities.

It has constructed multiple missile silos — without camouflaging them and with the awareness that they will be noticed by American satellites. Additionally, it displayed new and advanced nuclear delivery

systems in its 2025 military parade and carried out a land-based ICBM test in the Pacific Ocean in 2024.

China wants the world, and the US in particular, to take note of its improving nuclear capabilities. These developments can be attributed to factors such as China’s efforts to demonstrate the construction of its nuclear triad (having the capability to deliver nuclear weapons via land, sea and air).

It could also be attributed to China attempting to improve its second-strike capabilities, which are an extremely important part of its deterrence posture, since only India and China are the two declared “No-first-use” nuclear weapons states.

Beyond these simplistic explanations, these developments could also be attributed to China’s attempts to construct a nuclear shield, attain great-power status, or improve theatre-level nuclear dominance in the Indo-Pacific region.

Do these developments mean China’s nuclear strategy has changed?

No. The important pillars of China’s declaratory nuclear strategy are: i) No-first-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

use nuclear policy, ii) Assured retaliation, iii) Not to use or threaten to use nuclear weapons against non-nuclear-weapon states or in nuclear-weapon-free zones.

However, China also subscribes to a “minimum nuclear deterrent” posture. With recent changes in size, diversity, accuracy, and posture, there is evidence that China is shifting away from its minimum nuclear deterrence approach.

For instance, China could possess around 1,000 nuclear warheads by 2030. It is shifting at least a part of its force towards a “launch on warning” operational readiness posture, which Beijing refers to as “early warning counter-strike” — wherein Beijing initiates a counter-strike once a launch warning has been received but before targets in China have been hit.

What are the implications for Indo-Pacific actors, including India?

For New Delhi, the recent test reinforces the widening strategic gap between India and China’s nuclear arsenal and delivery capabilities — both qualitatively and quantitatively. While India has operationalised its

INDIA IS THE SECOND-BIGGEST EXPORT MARKET FOR RUSSIAN CRUDE

US bill proposes 100% tariffs on top five buyers of Russian energy

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 15

A REWORKED bill, backed by a bipartisan group of US senators, proposes up to 100% tariffs on the top buyers of Russian oil and natural gas, which include India and China. The move comes amid renewed Gulf crisis with experts calling it impractical. The bill, initially backed by the late US senator Lindsey Graham, was aimed at squeezing Russia's revenue from oil and gas exports. Following Graham's sudden demise last week, the group of US senators on Tuesday unveiled the revised version of the Russia sanctions bill.

Although it remains to be seen whether the bill will turn into law in its current form — considering the original bill failed to move beyond the initial phases for over a year — the proposed legislation would certainly be a cause of concern for New Delhi. Notably, the new bill is a watered-down version of the original, and does offer some room for workarounds and concessions from Washington. India is expected to push for those, if at all, the bill

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

is enacted, according to industry experts and analysts.

The new bill proposes tariffs of up to 100% on the top five buyers of Russian oil and natural gas, against the proposal of a blanket 500% tariff on buyers of Russian energy in the original version that had been hanging fire. While this reduction in proposed tariffs appears meaningful on paper, the cap is still too high for India, which is also working to finalise a trade deal with the US. Importantly, from New Delhi's perspective, the new bill gives powers to the US president to issue waivers on its provisions.

"India would almost certainly push for it (waiver), and it would make sense for the US to agree as a friendly concession, especially given how serious the situation is for New Delhi," Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona told *The Indian Express*. She added that the bill "risks colliding" with the India-US trade talks.

That would be counterproductive for both Washington and New Delhi, which have made progress in negotiations after initial setbacks and hiccups. The use of tariffs under



The new bill is a watered-down version of the original, and does offer some room for workarounds.

REUTERS

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mIjMzg1

the proposed law as leverage by Washington cannot be ruled out. Any such ploy by the US would create additional pressure on India. Even for Washington, taking away millions of barrels of Russian oil from the market when energy flows from West Asia remain stifled wouldn't be prudent. That would worsen an already worrying supply situation, sending oil prices soaring, something that the Donald Trump administration wouldn't want ahead of the US midterm polls.

Meaningfully reducing Russian oil imports is just not an

option in the prevailing circumstances of global supply tightness amid the West Asia crisis. As per Kpler data, India's Russian oil imports rose to 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd) in June, accounting for over half of New Delhi's oil imports. July could match or even exceed June's volumes.

"From India's perspective, Russian crude has become the country's strongest energy security hedge, particularly since the Strait of Hormuz disruptions. Russian barrels have enabled Indian refiners to maintain high refinery run

rates, ensure uninterrupted fuel supplies, and avoid the disruptions experienced by several other Asian refining systems," said Sumit Ritolia, modelling and refining manager at Kpler.

While there are calls from some US lawmakers to expedite the bill's passage, the prevailing energy market dynamics add an element of uncertainty. Nonetheless, India is expected to communicate its energy concerns to Washington, as was done last year as well when the original bill was mooted. Experts are also sceptical about the bill's prospects.

"The question is whether this bill is economically real at all. I simply do not see this bill passing, or remaining in its current form. It has already been diluted from a 500% tariff threat against virtually all buyers of Russian oil and gas to a maximum of 100% aimed at only the five largest. European exemptions and presidential waivers have also been added. That tells you the political slogan is already being adjusted to economic reality," said Katona.

FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● SINCE MID-JUNE, VESSEL MOVEMENTS THROUGH THE STRAIT HAD RISEN MEANINGFULLY, EVEN CROSSING 90 ON JUNE 24

Vessel transits via Hormuz crash to pre-MoU levels. Here's why

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 15

WITH THE US and Iran trading blows again, the movement of vessels through the Strait of Hormuz has dropped to its lowest in nearly a month, to levels seen before the US-Iran Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) took effect in June.

According to the latest available vessel tracking data from commodity market analytics firm Kpler, there were just 14 vessels crossing the strait on July 12 (Sunday), down from 24 on July 11 and 19 on July 10.

As per data from S&P Global, the last time ship transits were lower than this level was on June 14, three days before the US and Iran inked their peace deal on June 17.

The fall in maritime traffic through the strait, which usually accounted for a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows before the West Asia war broke out on February 28, has also sent oil prices higher. As of Wednesday evening, Brent futures were at about \$85 per barrel, having risen around 8% over the past one week.

Since mid-June, vessel movements through the strait had risen meaningfully, even crossing 90 on June 24, with the average being between 40 and 50 on most days, industry data shows.

But these were still lower than the pre-war levels of up to 140 daily transits.

Stark differences in MoU interpretation



Since the June MoU with the US, Iran has been insisting that vessels should cross the strait only through the routes designated by it, and that too after seeking its permission. Tehran also plans to impose a service fee

● OIL SHOCK

INDIA IS among the three most vulnerable Asian economies to high oil prices in terms of import bill and current account balances, the other two being Thailand and South Korea, according to a report by Nomura.

EVERY 10% oil price increase typically widens India's current account deficit by 0.4% of the GDP, it said.

for transits, but at a later date.

US President Donald Trump too announced a 20% transit fee, only to renege later.

The US and its allies have been encouraging vessels to use the strait's waters abutting

Oman as an alternative to Tehran-designated lanes. The stark differences in the MoU's interpretation and the vagueness in its terms have now emerged as the flashpoints in the uneasy ceasefire. Maritime data shows that ever since last week's fare-up, even the vessels crossing the strait are mostly doing so using paths designated by Iran.

"Confirmed Strait of Hormuz crossings declined by around 52% week-on-week over 10 to 12 July, with traffic reverting to more defensive routing patterns. Use of Iranian and dark routes increased while activity on IMO (International Maritime Organization) and Omani corridors almost disappeared," Kpler noted.

Dark shipping refers to vessels moving while keeping their Automatic Identification System (AIS) transponders off in a bid to avoid detection.

"The escalation is no longer confined to the Strait. Iranian retaliation has reached four Gulf states and Jordan. Qatar has suspended all maritime activity for the first time in the conflict, and the southern corridor, sustained through most of the reopening period by US escort under Project Freedom, has effectively collapsed, with only one of 12 outbound vessels using it on July 11," maritime intelligence provider Windward said in a note on Sunday.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

TEHRAN THREATENS TO SHUT MORE ENERGY EXPORT CORRIDORS, SAYS ‘NO PLANS FOR NEGOTIATIONS’

US launches new strikes on Iran as escalation threatens shipping

‘Saving it for last’: Trump says US will hit energy targets

Reuters
Cairo, Dubai, July 15

THE US conducted a new wave of strikes against Iran's coastal defence systems and missile sites on Wednesday after reimposing a naval blockade of Iranian ports, while Iran threatened to shut off more regional energy exports.

The daytime strikes mark the latest escalation of attacks and counterattacks launched by the two sides as they vie for control of the Strait of Hormuz.

"At 6 am ET (1100 GMT) today, US Central Command forces began launching a wave of strikes against Iran," the US military said. "The strikes are designed to further degrade military capabilities Iranian forces have used to attack commercial shipping in the Strait."

Iran's *Mehr* news agency reported US projectiles had hit a location on Iran's Hengam Island in the Strait of Hormuz.

US Central Command said the military had attacked coastal defence systems and cruise missile storage and launch sites on Iran's Greater Tunb Island, and had completed the wave of strikes within around 90 minutes. That followed seven hours of strikes Tuesday in which the US said it had hit dozens of military targets near the Strait and Iranian coastal areas.

In response, Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said Wednesday it had struck US military targets in the region, including in Bahrain, Kuwait and Jordan. It also threatened to shut off more regional energy exports, saying



People walk past a mural depicting the late leader of Iran's Islamic Revolution, Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, and late supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei on a street in Tehran on Wednesday. AP

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

the US "must brace for the closure of all other export corridors that benefit the US and its allies".

"We have no plans for negotiations at the moment and are focused on defence," *Tasnim* news agency quoted Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei as saying.

The IRGC said on Wednesday the Hormuz Strait would stay closed until what it described as "the end of America's evils". Analysts Iran is signaling it may use its Houthi allies in Yemen to shut Bab el-Mandeb, opening a new front against Washington and putting two of the world's most vital energy arteries at risk.

US President Donald Trump, who faces domestic pressure to avoid a full return to war, on Tuesday threatened to hit Iranian power plants and bridges next week unless Tehran resumes negotiations. "I'll save the energy targets for last, but ultimately we'll hit energy targets," Trump said.

Democrats block \$1.15tn defence bill over Iran war

Washington: US Senate Democrats blocked a \$1.15 trillion annual defense policy bill on Tuesday, citing frustration with the Iran war and President Donald Trump's failure to consult with Congress about his decision to send US forces into the conflict.

"Trump started this war without authorization, without a strategy, and without an exit," Senator Chuck Schumer of New York, the Senate's Democratic leader, said in a Senate speech announcing he would vote no.

REUTERS

Some ships ‘refusing’ US-military guided Hormuz transits after attacks

Five ships attacked in Omani waters since July 7: Data

Reuters
London, Athens July 15

SHIPPING COMPANIES are avoiding using a US military-guided transit scheme through the Strait of Hormuz after a wave of Iranian attacks on vessels sparked safety concerns, seven maritime security and shipping industry sources said.

For decades ships sailed into and out of the Gulf using a safe set of lanes down the middle of the strait established by the UN's shipping agency in 1968 dubbed the Traffic Separation Scheme.

Since the Iran war began on, Iranian forces have mined this area, forcing vessels to use one of

two makeshift routes close to either the Iranian or Omani coast. In June, *Reuters* reported that the US military had helped vessels through as part of an operation involving scores of secretive ship-to-ship oil transfers to keep Gulf energy exports flowing, using aerial and water drones as well as helicopters to guide tankers.

The US-assisted initiative enabled the export of tens of millions of barrels of oil. Yet shippers are evaluating the route on the Omani side of the strait as increasingly dangerous after a wave of attacks on ships.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards on Tuesday claimed responsibility for attacks on two Emirati oil supertankers. Some five ships have been attacked since July 7 – three crude supertankers, one LNG tanker and one container ship – in Omani waters that fell

under the US scheme, according to data from UN's shipping agency. It was unclear if all the ships were sailing under the US scheme, the sources said. "The US doesn't seem to have any control over the situation," one shipping source said.

"Iran's continued ability to target ships sailing through the Omani route means the Trump administration's proposed solution to keep ships moving is unlikely to work," said Torbjorn Solvedt, principal Middle East analyst with risk intelligence company Verisk Maplecroft.

White House officials did not respond to a request for comment. A US defence official said in the past seven days more than 100 vessels had directly coordinated with the US military to pass through the strait and over 300 had passed through the region more generally.



Warm Welcome Aboard ISS

A screengrab from a NASA video shows astronaut Anil Menon (giving a thumbs up) and Russian cosmonauts Pyotr Dubrov and Anna Kikina with fellow crew members after arriving at the International Space Station aboard the Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft on Wednesday. @NASA/YOUTUBE, PTI

Congo Ebola cases top 2,000 as more health workers go on strike

Associated Press
Bunia, July 15

THE NUMBER of confirmed cases of Ebola in Congo has reached 2,011, including 754 deaths, according to government data released overnight in what authorities say is the fastest-growing outbreak on record.

Health workers at Bunia General Hospital, the region's largest medical center, went on strike on Wednesday and are the latest group to have walked off their job at the epicenter over payment issues. Health



A health worker at an Ebola treatment centre in Bunia. FILE

professionals and other front line workers barricaded the entrance of the hospital, claiming they have not received any compensation despite working

under difficult conditions.

The World Health Organization says more than 100 health-care workers have been infected since the beginning of the outbreak.

The Central African nation has been battling the Ebola outbreak caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus since May 15. A total of 753 patients remain in isolation or in hospitals, while 366 have so far recovered, according to data from Congo's Ministry of Health. Contact tracing remains a challenge, with coverage of those exposed still at 67%.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1